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Week-09

Chapter # 07

**The Political System of
Islam**

The Political System of Islam

The Islamic political system is not merely a structure of governance but a comprehensive framework derived from divine revelation. Its core principles are designed to establish justice, uphold human dignity, and facilitate a society that lives in accordance with God's will.

Here is a detailed explanation of the key points with references from the Quran and Hadith.

1: Sovereignty Belongs to Allah (حَاكِمِيَّةِ اَعْلٰی)

This is the foundational principle of the Islamic political system. Ultimate authority, the right to legislate, and the source of all laws reside solely with Allah. Human beings, including rulers and states, are not sovereign; they are subject to and executors of divine law.

Allah says:

"Say, 'Indeed, I am on clear proof from my Lord, and you have denied it. I do not have that for which you are impatient. The decision is only for Allah. He relates the truth, and He is the best of deciders.'" (Al-An'aam 6:57)

Allah also says:

"Legislation is not but for Allah. He has commanded that you worship not except Him. That is the correct religion, but most of the people do not know." (Surah Yusuf 12:40)

This verse explicitly uses the term "Al-Hukm" (judgment, command, legislation), establishing that the right to make laws is a divine attribute.

Allah further says:

"And whoever does not judge by what Allah has revealed - then it is those who are the disbelievers." (Al-Ma'idah 5:44)

This strong statement highlights the gravity of replacing divine law with man-made systems.

While the concept is primarily Quranic, the entire practice of the Prophet Muhammad (ﷺ) was a living embodiment of this principle. He did not rule by his own personal opinion but by the revelation he received.

2: Vicegerency of Human Beings on Earth (Khilafah)

While sovereignty belongs to Allah, He has honoured humanity by appointing them as His Khalifah (vicegerent or trustee) on earth. This means that authority is a sacred trust (Amanah) bestowed upon humans to manage the affairs of the world according to Allah's commandments. This concept establishes that no individual, family, or class has an inherent, divine right to rule; leadership is a responsibility, not a privilege.

Allah says:

"And (mention, O Muhammad), when your Lord said to the angels, 'Indeed, I will make upon the earth a successive authority (Khalifah).'" (Al-Baqarah 2:30)

This verse establishes the very concept of humanity's vicegerency.

Allah also says:

"And it is He who has made you successors (Khala'if) upon the earth and has raised some of you above others in degrees (of rank) to test you through what He has given you." (Al-An'aam 6:165)

Allah further says:

"O David, indeed We have made you a successor (Khalifah) upon the earth, so judge between the people in truth and do not follow (your own) desire, as it will lead you astray from the way of Allah." (Surah Saad 38:26)

This verse was revealed about Prophet David and it directly links the position of Khilafah to the obligation of ruling with justice and truth.

The Prophet (ﷺ) said:

"Every one of you is a shepherd and is responsible for his flock. The leader of the people is a shepherd and is responsible for his subjects..." (Bukhari)

This hadith universalizes the concept of responsibility and trusteeship, from a head of state to a parent in a family.

3: Shura (Mutual Consultation)

Islam mandates the process of Shura (consultation) in managing public affairs. It is a mechanism for collective reasoning and seeking counsel from knowledgeable and representative people. This ensures that decisions are not autocratic but are considered and reflective of the community's welfare, within the boundaries of Shari'ah.

Allah says:

"And those who have responded to their lord and established prayer and whose affair is [determined by] consultation among themselves, and from what We have provided them, they spend." (Ash-Shura 42:38)

This verse praises the believers for making consultation a characteristic of their collective life.

Allah also says:

"So by mercy from Allah, (O Muhammad), you were lenient with them. And if you had been rude (in speech) and harsh in heart, they would have disbanded from about you. So pardon them and ask forgiveness for them and consult them in the matter. And when

you have decided, then rely upon Allah. Indeed, Allah loves those who rely (upon Him)." (Aali-Imran 3:159)

This verse, addressed to the Prophet himself, establishes the importance of consultation even for the highest authority.

According to Hadith, the Prophet (ﷺ) consistently consulted his companions on matters of strategy and public interest, such as at the Battle of Uhud and the Battle of the Trench. While the revelation was the final authority, the process of consultation was vital.

4: Rule of Law Based on Shari'ah

In an Islamic system, everyone, from the common citizen to the head of state, is subject to the same law—the Shari'ah. There is no one above the law. This establishes justice, equality, and protects the rights of all individuals.

Allah says:

"Indeed, Allah commands you to render trusts to whom they are due and when you judge between people to judge with justice..." (An-Nisa 4:58)

This verse establishes the core principles of justice and fulfilling trusts, which are the essence of the rule of law.

Allah also says:

"O you who have believed, be persistently standing firm for Allah, witnesses in justice, and do not let the hatred of a people prevent you from being just. Be just; that is nearer to righteousness..." (Al-Ma'idah 5:8)

According to hadith Reference; The most famous example is the following incident:

A woman from the powerful tribe of Makhzum committed theft. People interceded, asking Usama bin Zayd to plead with the Prophet (ﷺ) to pardon her. The Prophet (ﷺ) stood up and delivered a sermon, saying:

"The people before you were destroyed because when a noble among them stole, they would let him go, but when a weak person among them stole, they would execute the law upon him. By Allah, if Fatimah, the daughter of Muhammad, were to steal, I would cut off her hand." (Bukhari, Muslim).

This is a paramount example of the rule of law being applied equally to all, regardless of social status.

5: Accountability before Allah and People

Every individual in a position of responsibility is accountable, both to the people they serve and, ultimately, to Allah on the Day of Judgment. This dual accountability is a powerful check against the abuse of power.

Allah says:

"To Allah belongs whatever is in the heavens and whatever is on the earth. Whether you show what is within yourselves or conceal it, Allah will bring you to account for it..." (Al-Baqarah 2:284)

The concept of final accountability before Allah is a recurring theme, such as in Surah Az-Zilzal 99:7-8):

"So whoever does an atom's weight of good will see it. And whoever does an atom's weight of evil will see it."

The previously mentioned hadith, "Every one of you is a shepherd and is responsible for his flock..." (Bukhari), explicitly establishes the concept of accountability for those in charge.

The Prophet (ﷺ) also said:

"A ruler who, having control over the affairs of the Muslims, does not strive diligently for their betterment and does not serve them sincerely, will not enter Paradise with them." (Sahih Muslim)

This makes the ruler's sincere service a condition for his own salvation.

He (ﷺ) also said:

"The most beloved person to Allah on the Day of Resurrection and the closest to Him in position is a just leader, and the most hated person to Allah and the farthest from Him is a tyrannical leader." (Tirmizi)

Conclusion

The Islamic political system is a holistic model where:

- Allah's Sovereignty provides the ultimate source of law.
- Human Vicegerency confers the responsibility of governance.
- Shura provides the methodology for decision-making.
- The Rule of Shari'ah ensures justice and equality.
- Accountability acts as the ultimate safeguard against tyranny and corruption.

These principles are interlinked, creating a system whose primary goal is to establish a just and righteous society that fulfils its purpose of worshipping and obeying Allah.

Islamic State, Concept and Objectives

The concept of an "Islamic State" is rooted in the idea of implementing divine sovereignty (حاکمیت) and governing human affairs according to the principles revealed by God (Allah). It is not merely a political entity but a comprehensive system aimed at fostering a society that facilitates the worship of God and upholds justice, welfare, and moral excellence.

1: Definition and Core Characteristics

An Islamic State can be defined as a community-based political entity that derives its sovereignty, constitution, and primary legislation from the divine revelation of the Quran and the Prophetic tradition (Sunnah). Its ultimate goal is to create conditions where Muslims and non-Muslims can live in accordance with divine will.

Core Characteristics:

Sovereignty of God (Hakimiyyah):

The fundamental principle is that ultimate sovereignty and the right to legislate belong to Allah alone.

Allah says:

"The command is for none but Allah. He has commanded that you worship none but Him; that is the straight religion." (Surah Yousuf 12:40)

Allah also says:

"And He shares not His command with anyone." (Al-Kahf 18:26)

This means that no human assembly or individual has the absolute right to make laws that contravene divine guidance.

Governance by Shura (Consultation):

While sovereignty belongs to God, the administration of the state is conducted through consultation, reflecting a form of Islamic democracy.

Allah says:

"And those who have responded to their lord and established prayer and whose affair is (determined by) consultation among themselves, and from what We have provided them, they spend." (Ash-Shura 42:38)

Implementation of Shari'ah Law:

The state is responsible for implementing Islamic law (Shari'ah), which covers all aspects of life, including worship, transactions, family law, and criminal justice.

Allah says:

"And whoever does not judge by what Allah has revealed - then it is those who are the disbelievers." (Al-Ma'idah 5:44)

This verse, and those following it (5:45, 5:47), strongly emphasize the obligation to rule by divine law.

Bay'ah (Pledge of Allegiance):

The leadership is established through a mutual contract between the ruler and the people, where the people pledge obedience in exchange for the ruler's commitment to govern justly according to Shari'ah.

The Prophet Muhammad (ﷺ) said:

"He who dies without having pledged allegiance (to a Muslim ruler) dies the death of the Days of Ignorance (Jahiliyyah)." (Sahih Muslim)

2: Purpose: Justice, Welfare, and Moral Governance

The primary objectives of an Islamic State are to establish a just, prosperous, and morally upright society.

Establishing Justice ('Adl):

This is the cornerstone of Islamic governance. Justice is to be administered to all, regardless of faith, ethnicity, or social status.

Allah says:

"Indeed, Allah commands you to render trusts to whom they are due and when you judge between people to judge with justice." (An-Nisa 4:58)

Allah also says:

"O you who have believed, be persistently standing firm for Allah, witnesses in justice, and do not let the hatred of a people prevent you from being just. Be just; that is nearer to righteousness." (Al-Ma'idah 5:8)

Ensuring Public Welfare and Compassion (Rahmah):

The state is a vehicle for mercy and social welfare, responsible for the well-being of all its citizens.

The Prophet (ﷺ) said:

"The similitude of believers in regard to mutual love, affection, and fellow-feeling is that of one body; when any limb aches, the whole body responds with sleeplessness and fever." (Sahih Muslim)

The state must ensure the fulfilment of basic needs:

Food, shelter, clothing, and security for all. The Caliph Abu Bakr (RA) stated in his inaugural address;

"The weak among you shall be strong in my eyes until I secure their rights, and the strong among you shall be weak in my eyes until I take the rights from them."

Promoting Moral, Enjoining Good & Forbidding Evil:

The state has a responsibility to create a social environment that encourages virtue and discourages vice.

Allah says:

"You are the best nation produced (as an example) for mankind. You enjoin what is right and forbid what is wrong and believe in Allah." (Aali-Imran 3:110)

This is not merely a personal duty but an institutional one, implemented through education, social norms, and, where appropriate, state mechanisms, always within the boundaries of wisdom and justice.

3. Difference between Islamic and Secular Political Models

The Islamic political model differs fundamentally from the secular model.

Features of Islamic Model Vs Secular Model

1: Source of Sovereignty

In Islamic model, sovereignty belongs to Allah whose divine revelation is the supreme source of law.

In Secular model, sovereignty belongs to the people, human reason and popular opinion are the supreme sources of law.

2: Source of legislation

In Islamic model, the source of legislation is the revealed Text (Quran & Sunnah). Legislation must conform to divine principles. Human reasoning (Ijtihad) is used within this framework.

In Secular model, Human Reason & majority's opinion are the major sources. Laws are created by parliaments and can be changed by popular vote, with no higher moral reference than the will of the majority.

3: Objective of the State

In Islamic model, objective of the State is to facilitate the worship of God and establish His law on earth, ensuring justice and morality in this life and salvation in the hereafter.

In Secular model, objective of the State is to protect individual rights (especially liberty), promote material prosperity, and maintain public order. It is largely agnostic about the hereafter.

4: View of Human Nature

In Islamic model, the View of Human Nature is that the Humans are born with a natural disposition (Fitrah) to recognize God but are susceptible to weakness. The state helps nurture the Fitrah and restrain base desires.

In Secular model, it varies, but often views humans as rational, autonomous beings whose freedom should be maximized, with the state as a neutral arbiter.

5: Role of Religion

In Islamic model, role of Religion is integral. Religion is the foundation of public and private life. There is no separation between "mosque and state."

In Secular model, it is separated. Religion is largely a private matter and is separated from the functioning of the state and collective interest.

4: Overview of the Early Islamic State of Medina

The first Islamic State was established by the Prophet Muhammad (ﷺ) in Medina after the Hijrah (622 CE). It serves as the ideal practical model.

Some key features of Early Islamic State

The Constitution of Medina (Sahifat al-Madinah):

This was a formal written document, often considered the first constitution in history. It established:

- 1- The Muslim community of Muhajirun (Emigrants) and Ansar (Helpers) as a single Ummah (nation), distinct from other tribes.
- 2- A political and legal alliance that included Jewish tribes and other non-Muslims living in Medina. They were granted religious freedom and cultural autonomy in exchange for loyalty and a commitment to collective defence.
- 3- The Prophet Muhammad (ﷺ) as the ultimate political and judicial authority.

A Multi-Religious Society:

The Medina state was not an exclusively Muslim entity. It was a pluralistic society where rights and duties were clearly defined for all citizens, Muslims and non-Muslims alike, under the overarching authority of Islamic law.

Practical Implementation of Principles:

- 1- **Justice:** The Prophet (ﷺ) was famous for his impartial justice. He said, "By Allah, if Fatimah, the daughter of Muhammad, were to steal, I would have her hand cut off." (Bukhari)
- 2- **Welfare:** The system of Zakat (obligatory alms) was institutionalized, creating the world's first formal welfare state to eradicate poverty.

- 3- **Consultation (Shura):** The Prophet (ﷺ) consistently consulted his companions on major affairs, such as the strategy for the Battle of Badr and the Treaty of Hudaibiyyah.

This state in Medina became the blueprint for the subsequent Caliphates (Rightly Guided Caliphs and beyond), demonstrating how Islamic principles could be translated into a functioning, just, and prosperous political reality.

Conclusion

In summary, the Islamic State is conceptualized as a moral and legal entity whose authority is derived from God and whose purpose is to establish divine justice, ensure universal welfare, and promote a virtuous society. It stands in stark contrast to secular models by its submission to a transcendent source of law. The State of Medina remains the historical exemplar, demonstrating the practical application of these ideals in a diverse and complex social setting.

The Rightly Guided Caliphate (Khilafah ar-Raashidah)

The Khilafah ar-Raashidah (The Rightly Guided Caliphate) of the first four caliphs—Abu Bakr, Umar, Uthman, and Ali (may Allah be pleased with them)—is revered in Islamic history as a golden age of leadership based on piety, justice, and consultation. Here is a detailed analysis of it as a role model, highlighting the points you requested.

The Paradigm of Rightly Guided Leadership

The Rashidun Caliphate (632-661 CE) emerged immediately after the death of Prophet Muhammad (ﷺ). It represents a 30-year period where leadership was exercised according to the principles of the Quran and the Prophet's Sunnah, with a profound emphasis on justice, accountability, and public welfare. It serves as a timeless political and ethical model for many Muslims.

1: Historical Background and Legitimacy

- 1- **Context:** The Caliphate began in 632 CE after the Prophet's demise, creating a crisis of succession. The Muslim community in Medina needed a leader to maintain unity and guide the nascent state.
- 2- **Legitimacy Source:** Its legitimacy was derived not from hereditary right or military power, but from consent of the community as per the guidance of Allah and His Prophet.
- 3- **Consent of the Community:** The leaders were chosen by prominent companions (the Sahabah) and pledged allegiance to by the public (Bay'ah).
- 4- **Adherence to Revelation:** The caliphs were bound by the Quran and Sunnah. Their authority was temporal, not prophetic; they were servants of the law, not its makers.
- 5- **Personal Merit (Piety and Competence):** The central criterion for leadership was Taqwa (God-consciousness) and proven capability, not tribal lineage or wealth.

2: Selection of the Khalifa Process

The process evolved, demonstrating a practical model of consultation (Shura).

- 1- **Abu Bakr (632-634):** Elected in the wake of crisis at the Saqifah of Bani Sa'idah. After debate, a majority of companions pledged allegiance to him, recognizing his status as the Prophet's chief companion and his unwavering faith. This established the principle of election by the elite on behalf of the community.
- 2- **Umar ibn al-Khattab (634-644):** Appointed by Abu Bakr on his deathbed. Crucially, this appointment was not unilateral; Abu Bakr consulted prominent companions, and his choice of Umar was then ratified by the public through Bay'ah. This combined nomination with public consent.
- 3- **Uthman ibn Affan (644-656):** Selected by a six-member electoral council (Shura) appointed by Umar. The council had a clear mandate to choose a leader from among themselves through consultation. This is one of the clearest historical examples of institutionalized Shura.
- 4- **Ali ibn Abi Talib (656-661):** Acclaimed by the majority of Muslims in Medina after the assassination of Uthman, in what was essentially a public demand due to his renowned justice and closeness to the Prophet.

3: Administrative Structure and Justice System

The Caliphate evolved from a simple city-state to a complex empire, developing sophisticated structures.

- 1- **Decentralized Administration:** The empire was divided into provinces (Egypt, Syria, Iraq, etc.), each governed by a Waali (governor) appointed by the Caliph.
- 2- **Separation of Treasury:** Bait-ul-Mal (the Public Treasury) was established as a sacred trust. Revenues from Zakat, Jizyah, and Khiraj (land tax) were strictly accounted for and spent on public welfare—salaries, infrastructure, and support for the poor.
- 3- **Independent Judiciary:** The judiciary was separate from the executive. Judges (Qazis) were appointed for their knowledge and integrity and had the power to rule against the state or the Caliph himself, as famously happened with Caliph Umar.

4: Public Welfare, Transparency, and Accountability

This is a cornerstone of the Rashidun model.

- 1- **Welfare State:** The state was responsible for the well-being of all citizens, Muslim and non-Muslim. Pensions were established for the elderly, widows, and orphans. During a famine, Umar ensured food reached every citizen.
- 2- **Radical Transparency:** Caliphs lived simple lives and their finances were open to public scrutiny. Umar was known to explain public spending in detail from the pulpit.

- 3- **Direct Accountability:** Any citizen could question the Caliph in the mosque. There are famous incidents where a common woman corrected Umar during a sermon, and he accepted her correction, saying, "The woman is right and Umar is wrong."

5: Notable Examples of Leadership

- 1- **Abu Bakr's** Inaugural Speech: "Obey me as long as I obey Allah and His Messenger. If I disobey Allah and His Messenger, you have no obligation to obey me." This established the principle of conditional obedience.
- 2- **Umar's** Simplicity: He slept on a simple palm mat, wore patched clothes, and ate simple food, fearing he would be held accountable for the slightest misuse of public funds.
- 3- **Ali's** Equal Justice: He lost a legal case regarding a shield because he lacked witnesses, while his opponent had one. The judge ruled against the Caliph, and Ali accepted the verdict without question.

6: Abu Bakr (RA): Stability and Unity

- 1- **Crisis Manager:** Faced immediate apostasy wars and false prophets. He took a firm, uncompromising stand to preserve the integrity of the Muslim community and faith.
- 2- **Unifier:** His famous declaration, "If they refuse to pay a single camel rope (in Zakat) which they used to pay to the Messenger of Allah, I will fight them for it," underscored his commitment to unity based on established principles.
- 3- **Consolidator:** He initiated the compilation of the Quran into a single manuscript, ensuring its preservation for future generations.

7: Umar (RA): Justice and Governance Reforms

- 1- **The Epitome of Justice:** Known as Al-Farooq (the Criterion between right and wrong). He institutionalized justice, establishing courts and a regular police force.
- 2- **Administrative Innovator:** Founded the Hijri calendar, established the Diwan (a register for state pensions and salaries), and organized a census. He systematized the land revenue system in conquered territories.
- 3- **Conqueror with Principle:** Oversaw the conquest of the Persian Empire and much of the Byzantine Empire, but always ensured that the rights of the conquered peoples were protected under Islamic law.

8: Uthman (RA): Expansion and Economic Development

- 1- **Naval Power:** Established the first Islamic navy.
- 2- **Final Compilation of Quran:** Standardized the Quranic text and destroyed variant copies to prevent dispute, a project of immense historical significance.
- 3- **Economic Prosperity:** His calm and benevolent rule saw massive economic prosperity and expansion of the state. He authorized individuals to purchase and develop unused state lands, stimulating agriculture and commerce.

- 4- **Infrastructure Development:** He expanded the Prophet's Mosque in Medina and secured the city's water supply by purchasing a well for public use.

9: Ali (RA): Civil Justice and Principled Leadership

- 1- **The Scholar-King:** Renowned for his profound knowledge and unwavering principles. His letters to governors, such as the famous letter to Malik al-Ashtar, are masterpieces of Islamic political philosophy, emphasizing justice, compassion, and service to the people.
- 2- **Zero Tolerance for Nepotism:** Immediately recalled and replaced corrupt governors appointed by his predecessor, even if it meant political alienation.
- 3- **Upholding the Rule of Law:** His commitment to justice was absolute, even when it was politically costly. He prioritized principle over political expediency, setting a timeless example of integrity in leadership.

Conclusion

The Khilafah ar-Raashidah stands as a powerful role model not for its territorial expanse, but for its ethical and administrative principles. Its legacy is one of Shura (consultation), Adl (justice), Accountability, and Public Service. It demonstrates that an Islamic state is one where the ruler is a servant of the people and the law, where the treasury is a sacred trust, and where the ultimate goal of governance is to establish justice and enable the people to live dignified lives in accordance with their faith.